The matches were ferocious. Bowlers would tweak the ball hard and, bowling from no more than six metres, they would make each delivery spin and fizz, rear and bounce dramatically.

Batting seemed almost impossible.

Two or three fielders crowded the bat, taking advantage of the one-hand-one-bounce regulation, and they were 'supported' in the yard by a number of objects designated as additional fielders and deemed to have 'caught' the ball if it was struck against them on the full. There was one specific upright pole that held the clothes line and stood less than two metres from the batting crease. This pole was called Jonty because, in all those years of high-energy, frenetic back-yard cricket, he never, ever, ever dropped a catch.

Batsmen had to play with incredibly soft hands just to survive. If they wanted to score runs, and post any kind of total on the board, they had to be creative and to improvise, to guide the ball into vacant areas with all kinds of deft dabs, sweeps and glances. The back yard was a tough school, and a great school.

Jan and Wessels wrote the rules.

Anything hitting the kitchen door was out. Anything hitting any wall without bouncing was four.

This was not playtime.

Every game could scarcely have been more serious.

Each of us would select our own World XI, always fighting over who would have favourite players such as Jacques Kallis, Matthew Hayden and Adam Gilchrist. We would write down our teams on paper and each of us would bat through our entire order, walking away from the crease when you were out, writing down the score in the scorebook positioned just inside the kitchen door and then re-emerging as the next batsman.

Selection was often decisive. If you picked a left-hander, you would obviously have to bat left-handed when it was his turn to bat; that was a disadvantage, though not a bad training exercise.